to a place in the sun. Like China and India, Persia also has strong memories of ancient greatness that fuel aspirations of future regional pre-eminence. Iraq has been removed as an Arab and Sunni bulwark to Iranian advance; Iran now exercises great influence in that Shiite-majority land. Lebanon and Syria are also in the Iranian sphere. With Russian support, Iran has good prospects for consolidating hegemony over at least a part of Syria. Yemen, too, may be brought into the Iranian sphere. Even Saudi Arabia is showing cracks. The work of creating a new Persian empire establishing Iran as the dominant power in the Gulf in the face of US opposition will require foreign support for Tehran. Russia is currently Tehran's major backer. But, for deep historical reasons, chances are that Tehran will find Beijing a more comfortable, reliable, and capable supporter/partner over the long run. Tehran will probably play Beijing and New Delhi against each other to increase the support of both for an expanded Iranian role in the Gulf, just as the Shah did in the 1970s during his drive to establish Iran as the Gulf's "policeman." Tehran will invite Beijing and New Delhi to compete with each other, and they will probably play the new game laid out by Tehran.

A fourth and final factor giving rise to the new China–Indian rivalry in Iran is the change in both power's ties with the United States. Two factors have impelled China to adopt a much more confrontational approach to the United States: 1) a recalculation in 2008 of the balance between China and the West following the onset of the global financial/economic crisis and 2) Xi Jinping's takeover in 2012 and his mandate of a more proactive defence of China's interests against US encroachment. While China's leaders most assuredly do not envision military conflict with the United States any time soon, they do envision tolerating a higher level of tension and confrontation with the United States in defence of what they perceive as China's "core interests." This approach has led Beijing to view regional powers, like Iran, willing to "say